WRW

ISSUE 04
20 NOV 2026

FRANCHISE ENTRY REPORT

Kenya

Where the opportunity is, what blocks it, and what to do in the first 90 days.

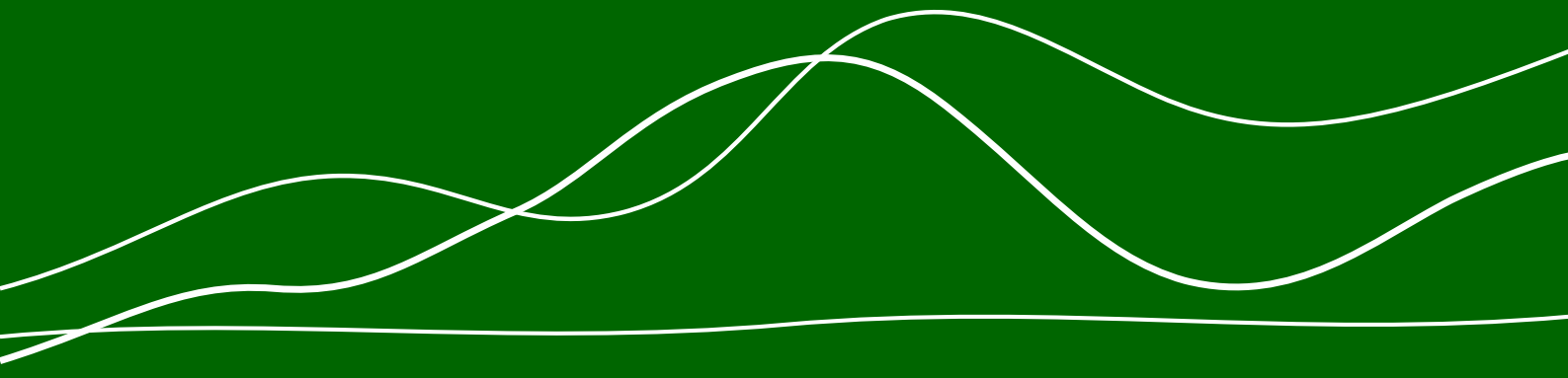
THE VERDICT

Open, with no franchise law found and a wage floor under £1 an hour. The catch: a small urban middle class and 14.4% borrowing. Chicken, coffee and forecourts are growing. Pick the partner before the category.

257
Simbisa counters in Kenya, Jun 2026, the largest food network we found

14.4%
average bank lending rate, Sep 2026, against a policy rate of 8.75%

£0.58
all-in hourly cost of a Nairobi waiter or cook at the legal floor (Estimate)



02 MARKET SNAPSHOT

A mobile-money market of 58 million, with its buyers in five cities

Kenya pays by phone, orders more by app every year, and keeps most of its buying power in Nairobi. Growth is in value and delivery, not in the bill per head.

Population

58.4m

Estimate for 2026: a straight line between KNBS projections of 57.0m for 2025 and 63.9m for 2030. We did not find a national urban share in the sources we could open.

KNBS via CEIC [S1]

GDP per head

USD 2,549

2025, KNBS Economic Survey 2026. About £1,910 at the CBK rate of 30 Oct 2026 (Estimate). Real growth was 4.6% in 2025. The CBK had estimated 5.0%, so we use the lower KNBS figure.

KNBS via HapaKenya [S2] · CBK [S3, S4]

Food-service spend

Not found

We searched the KNBS Economic Survey 2026, the household budget survey (the 2025/26 round is still in the field) and the CPI weights. Nearest proxy: Simbisa's Kenyan average spend was US$6.17 (about £4.63) a customer in Q3 of FY2026, on 3.5m customers.

KNBS [S2] · Simbisa via Food Business Africa [S5]

Franchise count

Not found

There is no official count, and we found no publications from a franchise association. The US trade desk calls the market "steadily growing". The three largest food networks we found add up to about 400 units (Estimate: Simbisa 257, Java House 95 in Kenya, KFC 48).

US ITA [S6] · Simbisa [S5] · Java [S7] · KFC [S8]

Consumer spending

Food prices +9.5%

In the year to Sep 2026, against 6.8% headline and 4.0% core inflation. Restaurant and accommodation prices were reported up 2.9% in August (basis unstated). We found no household confidence index. The CBK's September survey of firms (96 of them hotels) reports resilient festive bookings.

KNBS via Nairametrics [S9] · Standard [S10] · CBK [S11]

Currency · KES

£1 = KES 173.20

€1 = KES 144.74 and $1 = KES 129.95 on 30 Oct 2026. The shilling has held near 130 to the dollar for about 18 months. The CBK held at 8.75% on 7 Oct after ten cuts from 13.0% since Jun 2024. The next date was not yet posted.

CBK [S3] · Khusoko [S4]

How Kenya eats out

Three facts that shape every unit P&L

How they pay · Mobile

46.4bn

M-Pesa transactions in the year to Mar 2026, worth KES 41.68tn, through 3.13m merchants. The average ticket is about KES 898 (£5.18, Estimate, all uses).

Safaricom via TechTrendsKE [S12]

How it arrives · Delivery

27%

of Simbisa's Kenyan turnover came from delivery in FY2026, with orders up 59%. Glovo (12 towns), Uber Eats and Bolt Food operate. Jumia Food left in Dec 2023.

Food Business Africa [S5] · Business Radar [S13]

Where · Five cities

30.5%

of the middle class lived in Nairobi. The five cities below held about half (49.4% together, Estimate: sum of the bars). This is 2015 data, the latest split we found.



IEA via Business Daily, 2015 data [S14]

So what?

Food prices rose 9.5% in a year and bank loans cost 14.4%, so the margin is squeezed from both sides. We found no published restaurant margin. The largest operator grew visits 14% by letting average spend fall 3%. Kenya rewards a lean, value-led unit in the five cities, paid for by phone and sold through delivery. [S9, S3, S5]

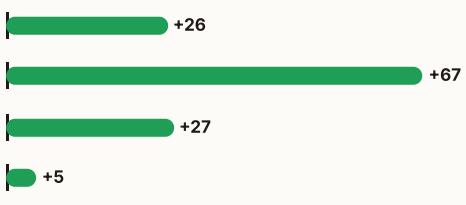
Chicken, coffee and forecourt food are growing. Burger, kebab, bubble tea and plant-based have no current count.

A rise or fall call needs two independent signals. Where we found only one, the row is marked Thin. We made no locator counts for this issue: every count is a company report or press, and the row says which.

CATEGORY	DIRECTION	EVIDENCE	SOURCE · WINDOW	CONFIDENCE	SATURATION	ENTRY
Chicken	↑ Rising	KFC went from 22 restaurants (Jun 2019, press) to 48 (Oct 2026, company figure), under one franchisee with a 50:50 venture with Vivo Energy. Simbisa (Chicken Inn, Galito's and others) went from 190 counters (Dec 2021) to 252 (Jun 2025) to 257 (Jun 2026), all brands. Chicken Cottage reached a ninth outlet on a Shell forecourt. We found no Kenyan coverage of Popeyes or Texas Chicken.	S8, S15, S16, S17, S5, S18 Jun 2019 → Oct 2026	Medium	Medium	Medium
Burger	Not found	No current count. Burger King opened at The Hub, Karen, in Nov 2016 and had 5 Nairobi outlets by Jun 2019, slowing its plans on cost. Big Square had 13 branches in Aug 2019. Famous Brands took Steers back from its franchisee of 23 years (court ruling, Jan 2021). We searched Business Daily, Nation and Capital FM for 2026 counts. Nearest proxy: the 2019 footprint, which points to a small category based in Nairobi. No McDonald's, Wendy's or Five Guys coverage found.	S19, S20, S21, S22 Nov 2016 → Jan 2021	Thin	Low	Medium
Pizza	Mixed	Facts only. Eat'N'Go bought the Domino's and Cold Stone Creamery master franchises for Kenya in Apr 2021 and had 18 branches across both in Mar 2022. Papa John's had 10 stores in Jan 2026 through Express Kitchen, with 8 more planned. Famous Brands reclaimed Debonairs from its franchisee in Jan 2021. Pizza Inn trades within Simbisa's 257 counters; we found no brand split.	S23, S24, S25, S21, S5 Apr 2021 → Jan 2026	Thin	Medium	Medium
Kebab / grill	Not found	We found no kebab chain. Galito's, Simbisa's flame-grilled chicken brand, trades in Kenya, but the annual report gives no brand split. We searched Simbisa's reports, Business Daily and the web for grill and kebab chains. Nearest proxy: nyama choma (roast meat) grills are run by independents we could not count.	S16, S5 Jun 2025 → Jun 2026	Thin	Low	Medium
Coffee	↑ Rising	Java House went from 75 stores in the region (Jul 2019) to 102 (Dec 2025: 95 in Kenya, 4 in Uganda, 3 in Rwanda). Bases may differ. It took its fourth owner since 2012 in Jan 2025. The Coffee Club signed a USD 5m master deal with a 14-station fuel retailer in Nov 2024. Artcaffe opened 11 outlets in 16 months to Apr 2021; we found no current count. No Starbucks found.	S20, S7, S26, S27, S28 Jul 2019 → Dec 2025	Medium	Medium	Medium
Bakery / dessert	Mixed	Artcaffe went from 4 to 11 cafés by buying 7 Dormans shops in 2014, a deal the Competition Authority approved. Cold Stone Creamery has no stand-alone count. Java's Planet Yogurt is also uncounted. We found no international bakery or doughnut chain in the sources we read.	S29, S24, S26 Jan 2014 → Jan 2025	Thin	Medium	Medium
Bubble tea	Not found	We found no chain, no count and no international entrant. We searched the web, delivery-app listings and Business Daily. Nearest proxy: Ketepa opened a Nairobi tea house in 2018 and said Kenyans drink 37m kg of tea, under 10% of what the country grows. The habit exists, but no branded chain has formed.	S30 Jun 2018	Thin	Low	Medium
Fast casual	Mixed	Subway's franchisee dropped the brand and runs the shops as Subz, with 10 branches listed in 2025 (blog, Thin). Famous Brands had 13 Kenyan franchise stores in 2014 and lost its master partner in 2021. Java's grilled-chicken brand Kukito had 7 outlets in Aug 2022 and aimed for 30 through franchising.	S31, S32, S21, S33 Apr 2014 → May 2025	Medium	Medium	Medium
Plant-based	Not found	We counted no plant-based chain. We searched HappyCow, lifestyle pages in Nation and The Star, and the web. The leads were independents we could not open. Nearest proxy: the three largest networks we found sell chicken, pizza and coffee, with no plant-based brand.	S5, S8, S7 Oct 2026	Thin	Low	Medium
Forecourt QSR Local category	↑ Rising	Vivo Energy opened its 350th Shell station in Kenya in Jul 2026, built as a convenience hub with food brands to follow. KFC's franchisee formed a 50:50 venture with Vivo in 2019 to open at its stations. Java opened two sites with Rubis in Feb 2024. The Coffee Club's master is a fuel retailer, and Chicken Cottage's ninth outlet is at a Shell station.	S34, S15, S35, S27, S18 Jun 2019 → Jul 2026	Medium	Medium	Medium

Change in unit count, selected chains

Units added over the window shown. Windows and bases differ, so compare direction, not size. All counts are company reports or press. KFC's start is a 2019 press figure and its end a 2026 company figure.



Sources: KFC [S15, S8]; Simbisa [S17, S5]; Java House [S20, S7]; Burger King [S19].

READING THE TABLE

What it means

1. Chicken holds the scale: KFC has **48** restaurants and Simbisa **257** counters across its brands. [S8, S5]
2. Visits are bought with value: Simbisa's Kenyan customers rose **14%** while average spend fell **3%**. [S5]
3. Forecourts are a route three brands have used: KFC with Vivo, Java with Rubis, The Coffee Club with a fuel retailer. [S15, S35, S27]

Four gaps, and the way in matters more than the category

A gap is a need with growing demand and no clear owner. The size of each one is our judgement of the prize for a new entrant: S, M or L.

1 Forecourt-first QSR

GAP	Fuel retailers are turning stations into food stops, and we found few food brands on them. A fuel-retailer partner can bring the site, the lease and the traffic.
EVIDENCE	Vivo's 350th Shell station opened in Jul 2026 as a convenience hub. KFC, Java and The Coffee Club all entered or grew through fuel retailers. [S34, S15, S35, S27]
SUITS	Compact chicken, coffee and grab-and-go formats with a short menu.
ROUTE	Master franchise held by a fuel retailer, or a joint venture.

L Large prize

2 The five-city build-out

GAP	The buyers sit in five cities, and the delivery apps already serve towns beyond Nairobi. Counts outside the capital are thin, but openings there are recent.
EVIDENCE	Glovo runs in 12 towns, and Uber Eats in Nakuru and Eldoret. Java opened in Eldoret in Dec 2025. International arrivals reached 2.76m in 2025/26, up 9.8%. [S13, S7, S36, S37]
SUITS	Brands with a proven Nairobi unit that can run on a regional supply chain.
ROUTE	Area developer, or a master partner with a regional plan.

M Medium prize

3 Value-led, delivery-ready menus

GAP	The largest operator is growing visits by cutting the bill, and delivery is over a quarter of its sales.
EVIDENCE	Simbisa: customers +14%, average spend −3%, delivery orders +59% and 27% of turnover in FY2026. Glovo lists 6,000+ merchants. [S5, S13]
SUITS	Brands with a low-price core menu that travels well.
ROUTE	Master franchise with an operator that already runs delivery.

M Medium prize

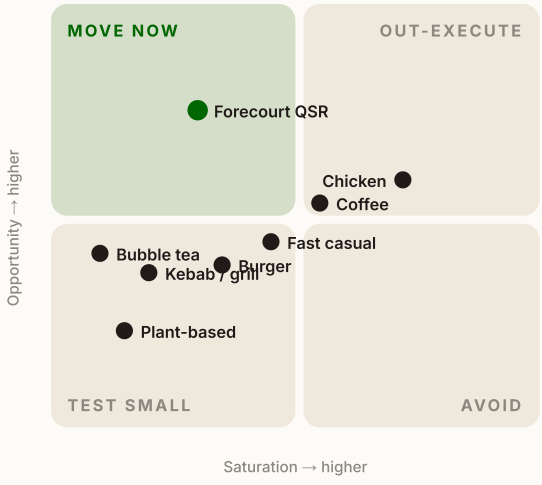
4 Branded tea and bubble tea

GAP	A tea-drinking country with no branded bubble-tea chain found.
EVIDENCE	Ketepa's 2018 Nairobi tea house, and 37m kg of local tea consumption. No chain or international entrant found. Demand data: Not found. [S30]
SUITS	Low-capex kiosk and in-mall formats.
ROUTE	Direct franchise with one strong Nairobi partner.

S Small prize *Thin evidence*

Opportunity vs saturation

Our assessment from the page 3 evidence. Position is judgement, not measurement.



Pizza and bakery are left off: mixed signals and no like-for-like counts. Source: WRW Hospitality analysis of the page 3 evidence.

IF I HAD A BRAND

> **If I had a brand going into Kenya, I'd pick the partner before I picked the site.**

The brands that scaled came in on someone else's footprint: KFC on Vivo's forecourts, Java with Rubis, The Coffee Club with a 14-station fuel retailer. Labour is cheap. Money and food are not: 14.4% to borrow and 9.5% food inflation.

Two partnerships ended badly. Famous Brands took its stores back from its franchisee of 23 years, and Subway's franchisee kept the shops as Subz. I'd write credit checks, step-in rights and site assignment into the deal first, then choose the category.

Wesley Williams, WRW Hospitality

05 REGULATION AND COST TO OPERATE

No franchise law, cheap labour, and costs that sit in money, food and tax

We found no franchise statute, so the contract does the work. The legal wage floor is low. Borrowing, food and withholding tax are the lines to model first.

AREA	CURRENT POSITION (VERIFIED OCT 2026)	SOURCE
Franchise law	**No franchise-specific law or disclosure duty found.** Contract, competition, trade mark and county law apply. We searched Kenya Law, the US trade desk's franchising guide and law-firm summaries, and found no current publications from a franchise association.	S6
Trade mark	KIPI fees for a foreign applicant: US$200 to apply (US$150 for each extra class), US$60 to advertise, US$150 to register. Recording a franchisee as a registered user costs US$300. ARIPO and Madrid coverage: not confirmed. Budget a year.	S38
Company	Companies Act 2015, s. 975(2): a foreign company registering a branch must meet a 30% Kenyan-shareholding criterion, which was debated in 2018. **Licensing a local master avoids the question.** Confirm with a Kenyan adviser.	S39
Licensing and halal	County permit and food-hygiene fees: Not found from a primary source. We tried Nairobi County, KenInvest and a Capital FM guide (blocked), and the fees quoted in search results conflict. The Kenya Bureau of Halal Certification runs a meat and poultry standard. Muslims are about 11% of the population (2021).	S40
Tax	Corporate tax is 30%. VAT is 16%, with registration above KES 5m of supplies. **No takeaway concession found.** A 2025 proposal to exempt restaurant services was not confirmed as enacted.	S41, S42, S43
Royalties	Withholding to a UK franchisor under the treaty: royalties 15% (20% domestic) and management fees 12.5%. Get a ruling on whether an initial fee counts as a royalty. Remittance rules: not found from a primary source.	S44
Import duty	EAC common external tariff. The FY2026/27 changes raised furniture from 35% to 45% and list no change for restaurant equipment or food inputs. Rates by tariff code for equipment, chicken, chips, oil and dairy: not found.	S45

Trade mark, one class

US$ 410

KIPI foreign-applicant fees to apply, advertise and register, before agent fees (Estimate). [S38]

VAT on restaurant meals

16%

Standard rate. No takeaway concession found, unlike Sweden. [S42, S43]

Withholding on royalties

15%

To a UK franchisor under the treaty, against 20% domestic. Management fees 12.5%. [S44]

THE WAGE ENGINE

Model the unit on Kenyan money, not Kenyan wages

What every KES 100 of pay costs the employer



● Wage 100 ● NSSF (employer) 6.00 ● Housing levy 1.50 ● NITA levy 0.26

Total ≈ 107.8

ESTIMATE NSSF employer 6% of pay up to KES 108,000 (Year 4 rates, Feb 2026), the Affordable Housing Levy employer share of 1.5%, and NITA at KES 50 a month at the floor wage (it may not apply to restaurants). We found no employer share for SHIF, the health levy deducted from staff. Overtime, leave and service pay are excluded. [S46, S47, S48]

LEGAL WAGE FLOOR

KES 19,491

A month, for waiters and cooks in Nairobi, Mombasa, Kisumu, Nakuru and Eldoret, from 1 May 2026. This is the press report of the Gazette order; we did not open the order itself. [S49, S50]

ALL-IN FLOOR

≈ £0.58/hr

ESTIMATE KES 20,953 a month ÷ 208 hours (48-hour week; statutory hours not found) ≈ KES 100.7 an hour, at £1 = KES 173.20 on 30 Oct 2026. [S3, S50]

Not legal or tax advice. Confirm the position with a Kenyan adviser before signing.

Pick the partner first. Then price the risk.

Each route trades control against capital and speed. The examples show how brands came into Kenya, and how two partnerships ended.

ROUTE	YOUR CONTROL	YOUR CAPITAL	SPEED TO SCALE	SEEN IN KENYA
Master franchise, local operator	○○○	○○○	●●○ Medium	Eat'N'Go took two US master franchises in Apr 2021. Express Kitchen had 10 Papa John's stores by Jan 2026. Famous Brands' master partner from 1997 lost the licence in 2021. [S23, S25, S21, S32]
Fuel retailer, master or joint venture	○○○	○○○	●●● Fast	KFC's franchisee and Vivo Energy formed a 50:50 venture in 2019, and KFC went from 22 to 48 sites. The Coffee Club signed a USD 5m master deal with a fuel retailer in Nov 2024. [S15, S8, S27]
Home-grown franchising	○○○	○○○	●●○ Medium	Java's Kukito: 7 outlets in Aug 2022, aiming for 30 through franchising. Artcaffe grew by buying Dormans' 7 shops instead. One planned example found. [S33, S29]
Company-owned, local subsidiary	○○○	○○○	●○○ Slow	Simbisa runs its Kenyan counters itself (252 to 257). Famous Brands has run its Kenyan stores itself since 2021. Java House has had four owners since 2012. [S16, S5, S21, S26]

Emerging brand

A fuel-retailer partner

Under c. 25 units. A fuel retailer can bring sites, leases and traffic that are hard to buy from abroad. KFC, Java and The Coffee Club all grew or entered through fuel retailers.

Mid-size brand

A local master, credit-checked

Proven in 2 countries. Check the partner's balance sheet: Famous Brands' master of 23 years owed banks over KES 67m when it lost the licence.

Global brand

A joint venture with a retailer

KFC's franchisee and Vivo Energy set up a 50:50 venture across Kenya, Uganda and Rwanda in 2019. KFC now has 48 Kenyan restaurants.

Price the risk before you price the franchise

Six risks, each sourced

Currency and remittance

The shilling has held near 130 to the dollar for about 18 months, but royalties are earned in KES. We found no primary source on remittance rules. The treaty withholds 15% on royalties. [S3, S4, S44]

Cost of borrowing

Bank loans averaged 14.4% in Sep 2026, against a policy rate of 8.75% after ten cuts. A franchisee's fit-out is funded at the higher rate. [S3, S4]

Food and supply

Food prices rose 9.5% in the year to Sep 2026, against 6.8% overall, after drought and the Middle East conflict. Cold-chain and local supply data for chicken, potatoes, dairy and oil: not found. [S9]

Partner credit

Famous Brands' master partner owed KES 6.1m in royalties and over KES 67m to banks before the licence was reclaimed. Subway's franchisee kept the shops as Subz (blog, Thin). [S21, S31]

Delivery economics

Uber agreed to buy Delivery Hero, which would put Glovo and Uber Eats under one owner, subject to Competition Authority review, with completion expected in H2 2027. Jumia Food left in Dec 2023. Commission rates: not found. [S51, S13]

Protest, security and rent

Protests damaged some of Simbisa's city-centre stores in FY2025, and new taxes cut its customer count 6%. A Nairobi venue faces a KES 16.5m rent claim, with KES 10.8m in arrears. [S16, S52]

Ten moves, in order, before you sign anything

1. **File the trade mark** with KIPI, and record each franchisee as a registered user.
2. **Shortlist 3 to 5 partners** among fuel retailers and multi-brand operators.
3. **Credit-check the partner** and write step-in rights, site assignment and a non-compete into the master agreement.
4. **Rebuild the unit P&L** on Kenyan costs: rent, 14.4% money and 9.5% food inflation, not only the wage floor.
5. **Model the royalty net of 15% withholding,** and get a ruling on how the initial fee is taxed.
6. **Confirm VAT on restaurant meals** with the Kenya Revenue Authority before you price the menu.
7. **Count the competition yourself:** dated locator counts for KFC, Simbisa's brands and Java House, city by city.
8. **Price delivery at more than one commission rate,** and plan for one owner of Glovo and Uber Eats.
9. **Plan the licence path** for the first site: county permit, food hygiene and halal certification.
10. **Agree how royalties are paid** in KES and converted to sterling.

WHAT WE'D CHECK NEXT

- Mall QSR tenant counts at Two Rivers, Garden City, Sarit, The Hub and Village Market
- The Gazette wage order and statutory hours for restaurant staff
- VAT on restaurant meals after the Finance Act 2025
- Simbisa's counts by brand, and current Burger King and Artcaffe counts
- ARIPO and Madrid coverage, and delivery commission rates

METHOD

Public sources only, read 30 Oct 2026. Every figure is dated and coded to the list below. Rise and fall calls need two independent signals; otherwise they are marked Thin. Estimates are labelled with their method. Not found is used only after a search, with the nearest proxy. All unit counts are company reports or press: we made no locator counts for this issue. Not legal, tax or investment advice.

Sources

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Which country should we cover next?

Tell us in the comments. Follow WRW Hospitality for the next Franchise Entry Report, every Friday.

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